

IN PRACTICE

Rituals and celebration

Modern Wiccan rituals can take on almost any form according to the particular tastes of any given coven and what is being commemorated. The most common rituals are those that celebrate the Sabbats: the solstices, the equinoxes, and the “cross-quarter days” that fall between them. Worshippers often create lavish displays of seasonal foliage and flowers, and they may recite prayers and poems for healing or merely to reflect the blessings of the seasons. Participants always invoke the God and Goddess and the four elements, and sometimes a fifth: Akasha (the spirit). They may call upon the four cardinal points, too.

A woman sets up an altar to celebrate a Wiccaning (the blessing of a baby recently born to Wiccans).



21st-century millennials. It is also open to endless reinterpretation. In North America, it was first championed by British-born Raymond Buckland; in 1964, he proclaimed himself the first Wiccan in the US, simultaneously asserting the primacy of Anglo-Saxon influence on Wicca. In the 1970s, an American journalist, Margot Adler, was equally influential in spreading the Wiccan creed. At around the same time, also in the US, Hungarian-born Zsuzsanna Budapest championed Wicca as a mainstay of feminism, and only worshipped female deities. Since then, Norse Wicca, Celtic Wicca, Druidic Wicca, Solitary Wicca, and Eclectic Wicca have also emerged. Among the most vocal Wicca champions are environmentalists.

It is estimated that today there are as many as 1.5 million Wiccans in the US alone. Whatever its journey from Gerald Gardner’s imagined world of the occult in the 1940s, modern witchcraft remains an extraordinary testament to a continuing human need for—and belief in—magic.

“The Goddess is alive.
Magic is afoot.”

ZSUZSANNA BUDAPEST, WICCAN AUTHOR, 2010